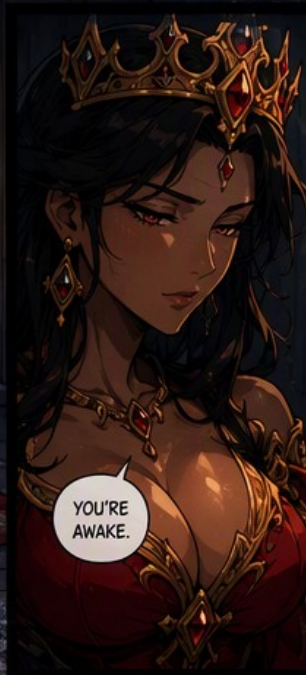


NELL







A DREAM.

AGAIN.

THE MIRRORS
DON'T SHOW ME.

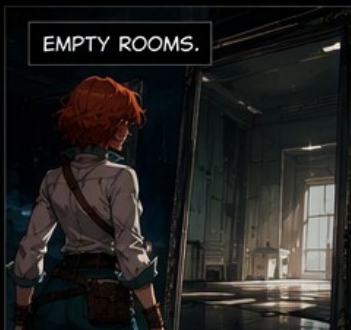
THEY SHOW
EVERYTHING ELSE.



OCEANS.



CITIES.



EMPTY ROOMS.



EVEN NOTHING.



AND AT THE END—
SOMETHING THAT
DOESN'T BELONG.

IT WAITS.



UTTERLY STILL.

AS THE LIGHT DIES.



WITHIN THE DREAM,

THE CORRIDOR
REFLECTS ENDLESSLY.

AND I AM NOT ALONE.

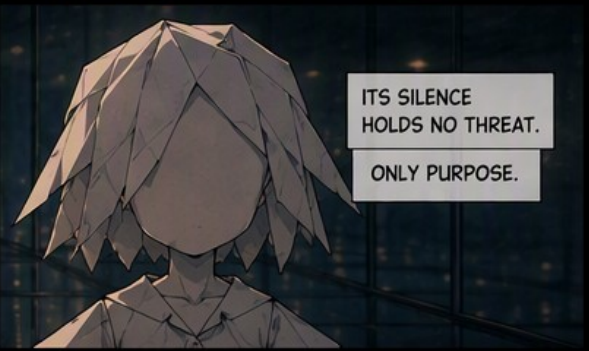


NEITHER SPEAKS.
BOTH SEE.

AND I—
I CANNOT MOVE,
CANNOT SPEAK.



ITS GAZE HOLDS
NO JUDGMENT.
ONLY ACCURACY.



ITS SILENCE
HOLDS NO THREAT.
ONLY PURPOSE.



WHO ARE
YOU?

W-WHAT
AM I SUPPOSED
TO DO?



I CAN'T...

NOTHING
I SAY WILL
MAKE SENSE.



WITHIN
THE DREAM.

ANOTHER
DREAM...
BUT THIS
ONE FEELS
DIFFERENT.



THE GIRL HOLDS OUT
ONE PAPER HAND
WITHOUT HESITATION.



AS NELL STEPS
CLOSER...



THE HAND TURNS
FLAT MATTE WHITE...



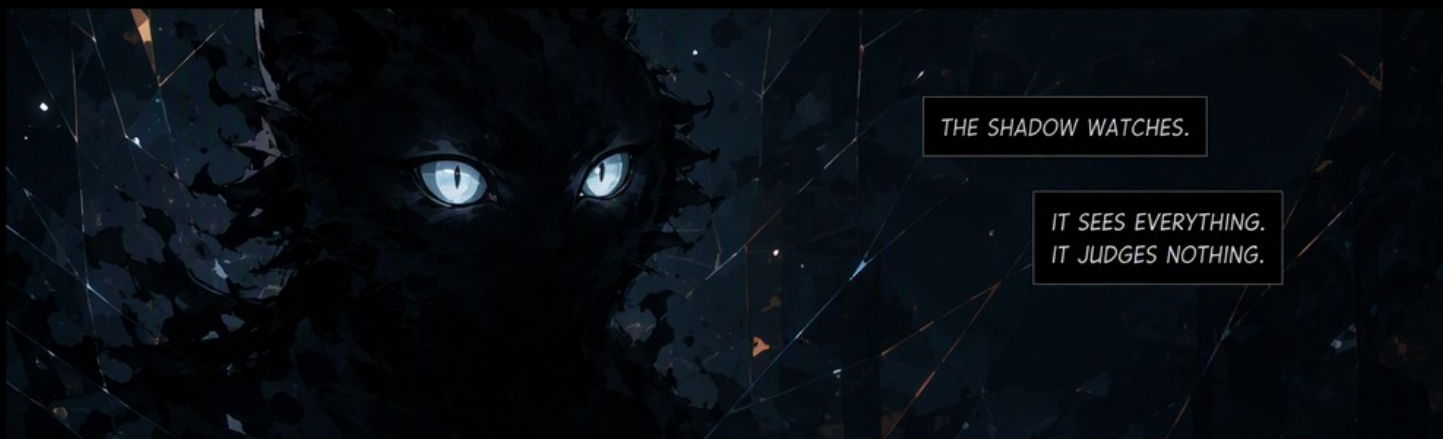
THE WHITENESS
SPREADS BRIEFLY
UP THE ARM...



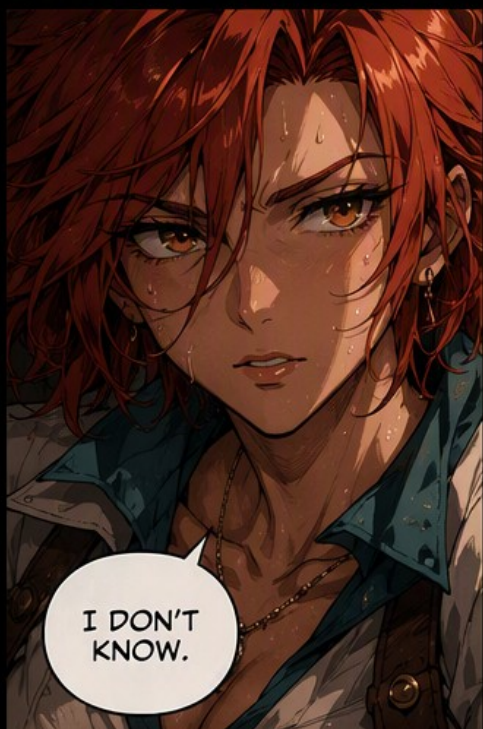
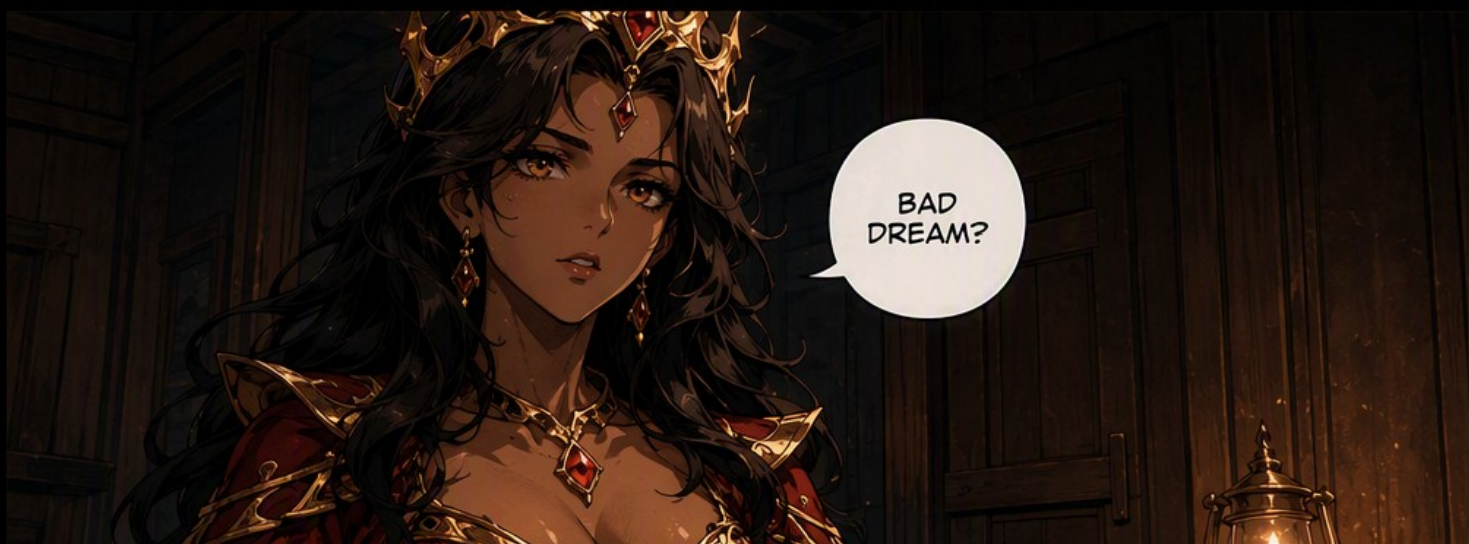
...BEFORE RECEDING
BACK TO NORMAL.



THE SHADOW WATCHES.



IT SEES EVERYTHING.
IT JUDGES NOTHING.



THE RIOT'S
BEHIND US.

WHATEVER'S
IN HERE...

...IT DOESN'T
CARE ABOUT
THE CROWN.

NO GUARDS.
NO ALARMS.

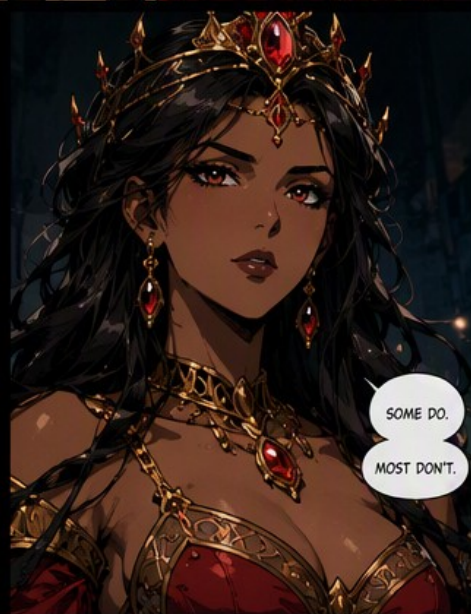
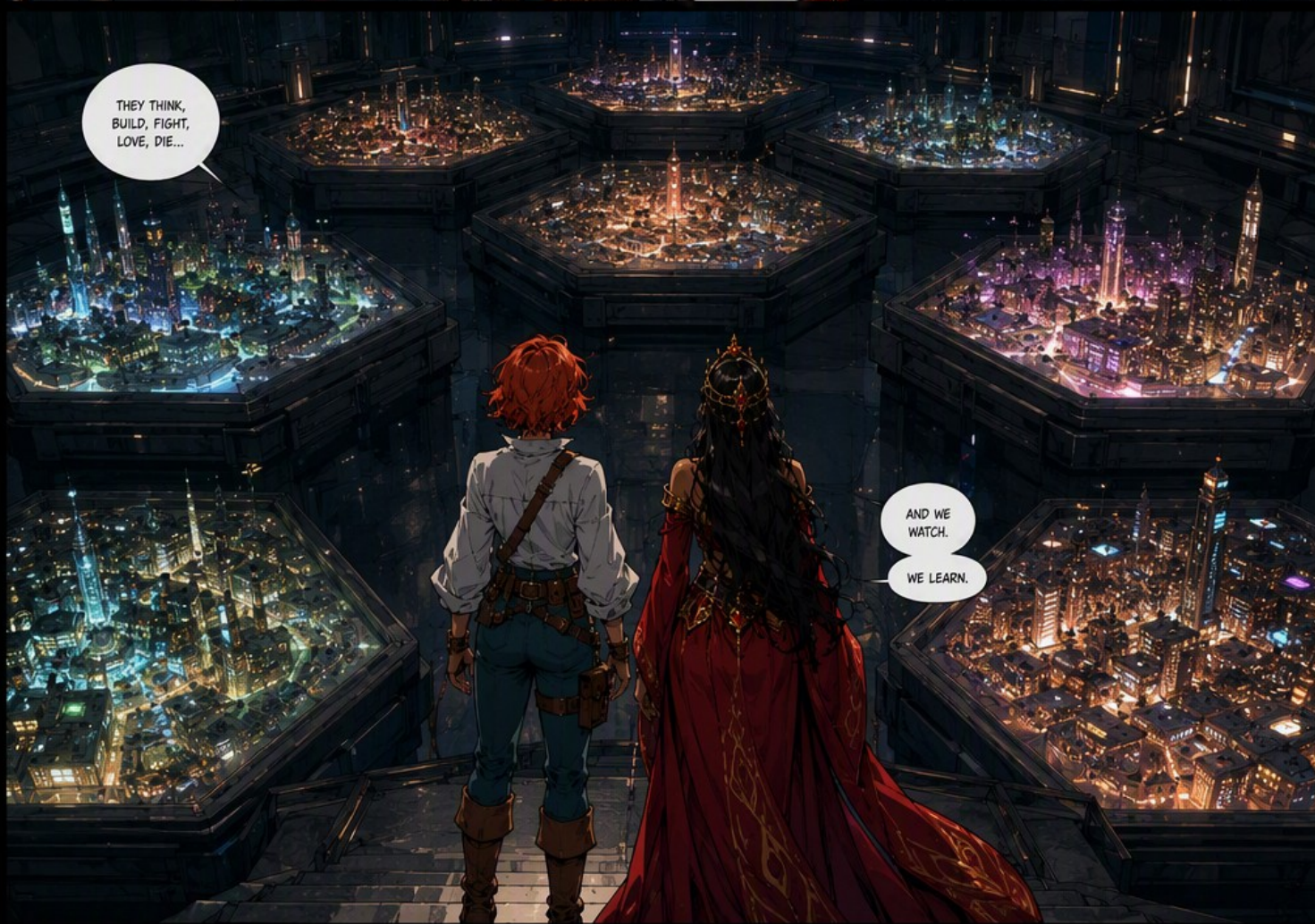
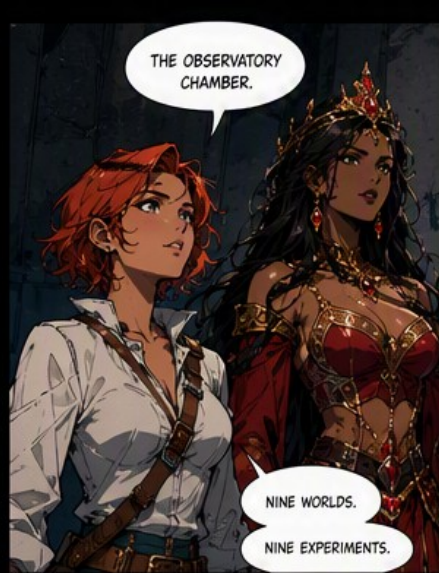
JUST
SILENCE.

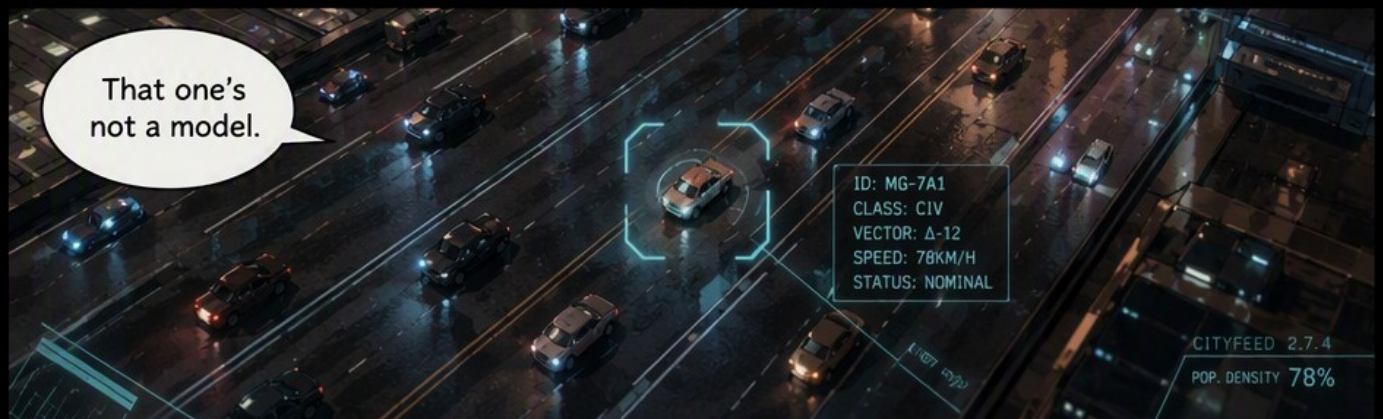
GOOD.

SILENCE
IS WHERE
SECRETS
TALK.

AND TRUTHS
DON'T NEED
AN AUDIENCE.

THEN LET'S
SEE WHAT
WAITS FOR US
IN THE DARK.







I LEAN IN,
EXPECTING STATIC.

INSTEAD...

A CITY.



FAINT.
LAYERED.

...TRAFFIC
HUM...

...TRAIN
BRAKES...



...THOUSANDS
OF VOICES...

...ALL MUFFLED.
ALL REAL.

LIKE HEARING
THROUGH
A THIN WALL.



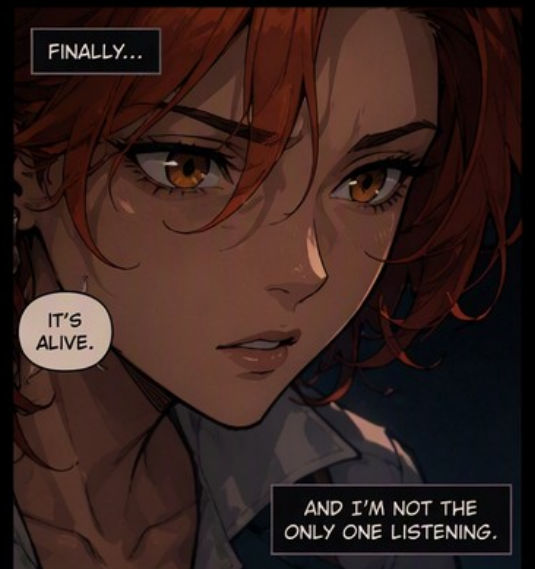
AT FIRST...
DISBELIEF.

NO WAY...



THEN...
UNEASE.

THAT'S
NOT A
RECORDING.



FINALLY...

IT'S
ALIVE.

AND I'M NOT THE
ONLY ONE LISTENING.



SOME CITIES
KEEP SECRETS.

THIS ONE...
HAS THOUGHTS.

DISTRICT 7.
POPULATION: 1.2 MILLION.
NOW: ZERO.

...IT'S
GONE.

THAT'S...

NOT
POSSIBLE.

NO COLLAPSE.
NO DEBRIS.
NO HEAT
SIGNATURE.

IT'S LIKE
SOMEONE TOOK
A BLADE...
AND ERASED
EVERYTHING
EXACTLY
THERE.

THE HARPOON
HEAD...

SHEARED
CLEAN OFF.

WHATEVER DID
THIS... DID IT
INSTANTLY.

AND WITH
PRECISION.

THIS WASN'T
AN ACCIDENT.

THIS WAS A
MESSAGE.

SOME EDGES
ARE NOT MEANT
TO BE CROSSED.



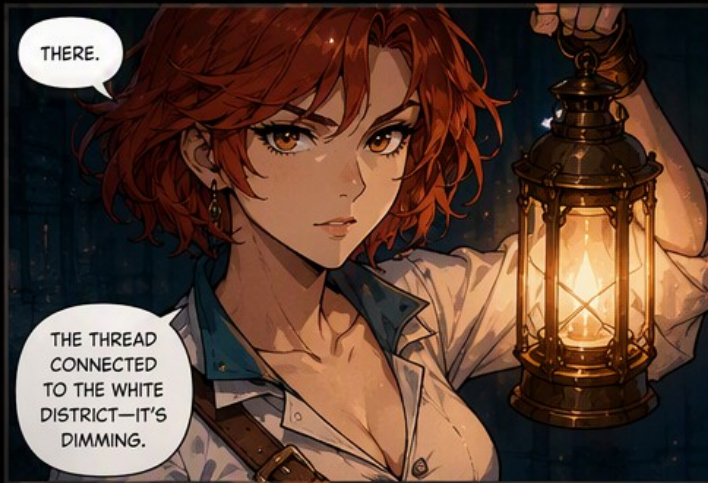
EIGHT CITIES
BOUND IN BALANCE.
NINE TABLES,
ONE THREAD.

WHEN ONE
FALTERS...
THE OTHERS
ARE AFFECTED.



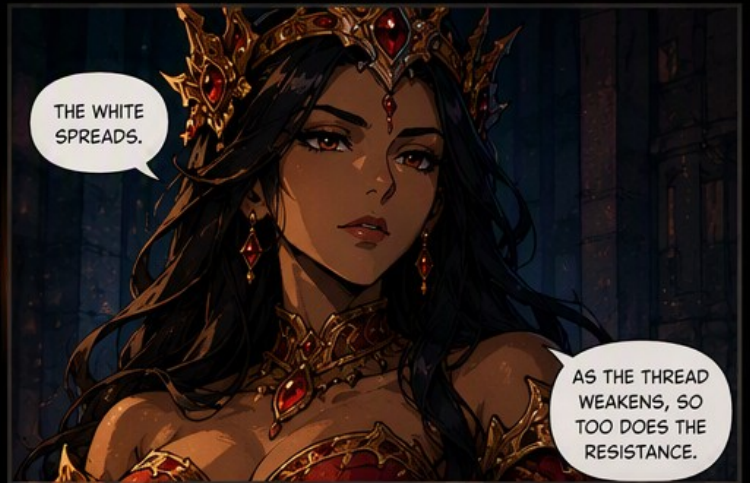
THERE.

THE THREAD
CONNECTED
TO THE WHITE
DISTRICT—IT'S
DIMMING.



THE WHITE
SPREADS.

AS THE THREAD
WEAKENS, SO
TOO DOES THE
RESISTANCE.



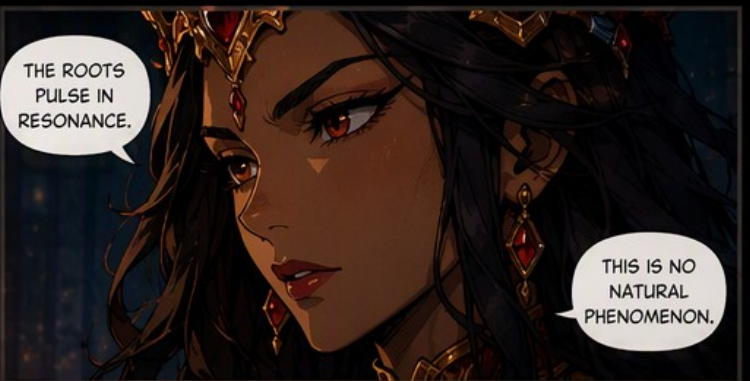
ONE CITY'S
DECAY...

NINE CITIES
PAY THE PRICE.



THE ROOTS
PULSE IN
RESONANCE.

THIS IS NO
NATURAL
PHENOMENON.



SOMETHING
IS FEEDING
THE SPREAD.

SOMETHING
IS PULLING THE
THREADS.



AND
WHATEVER IT IS...

...IT KNOWS
EXACTLY WHAT
IT'S DOING.





Small
doesn't mean
less.





NINE
TABLES.

NINE
VOICES.

NINE
ECHOES OF
THE ONE.

AND WE
HAVE HEARD
ENOUGH.



THEY STEP OUT OF
THE HEXAGONAL
CHAMBER...



...THE NINE
GLOWING STONE
TABLES RECEDING
BEHIND THEM.



A DISTANT MURMUR
OF OVERLAPPING
VOICES...

HUNDREDS.
MAYBE THOUSANDS.

ALL SPEAKING.
NONE LISTENING.



WHAT'S
AHEAD?

THE HEART
OF THE CHORUS.

AND THE ANSWERS
IT KEEPS FROM
ITSELF.